A round trip through censorship, graphic design and publishing

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Master's in Visual Communication

In 1972, the 'Three Marias' wrote a book, 'Novas Cartas Portuguesas' (New Portuguese Letters), created 'by six hands.' Three days after its publication, the Portuguese authoritarian state censored the edition, arrested the authors, and destroyed the printing plates. They were put on trial for outraging public decency, an event that sparked an international feminist solidarity movement.

December 2023

This project roughly started two years ago, during my bachelor's degree, when I wrote a project proposal for a class called publishing. I couldn't develop it then due to time limitations. At the time, the project was called "Erasing Blue Pencil," proposing the republishing of censored books during the 50-year Portuguese Dictatorship (1). I was influenced by the rise of the topic due to the then-upcoming 50-year celebration of the Carnation Revolution, which put an end to this dictatorship, where censorship was its main weapon. I then decided to apply to a master's program where I'd develop this project.



(1) 50 year Portuguese Dictatorship: Portugal was under one of the longest European dictatorships of the last century. Until the Carnation Revolution in 1974, this fascist regime systematically attacked self-expression, civil liberties, and independent thought, utilizing state censorship as its primary weapon to silence dissent and control public discourse.

September 2024

So then I arrived here, in Stockholm, and at Konstfack. And as the months passed, this project felt constraining, this master's had such exploratory potential, why should I stick to this project proposal I created for a random Erasmus class??. In a silly way, as the significant date of the 50 years of the Carnation Revolution was passing, the theme seemed not as urgent to me at the time.



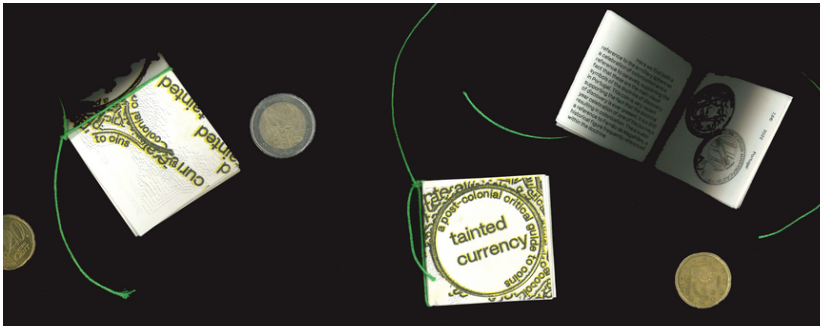
October 2024

In my first course here, I explored various topics. I redid a photobook revolving around trash in urban areas.



January 2025

Then, crafted a coin-sized publication, analysing how colonialism is prevalent in the visual elements of our currency, focusing on euro coins.



February/March 2025

After this, it was time to refocus on my master's project, and I still wanted to work with censorship. In what way? I didn't know!
So I tried a million things, from gelli plating social media censorship to creating a website typeset on the printing press.



April/May/June 2025

After starting a heavy theoretical research.
I became mainly interested in the topic of New Censorship Theory, which moves beyond traditional views of censorship as explicit, state-imposed bans to include pervasive, often invisible forms of control, and focuses a lot on other mechanisms of censorship.
Such as self-censorship!
With an upcoming exhibition, I felt the need to share this theoretical research visually.
And decided to use my favorite medium, a publication. After the exhibition had happened.
I had mixed feelings. While feeling that my work was appreciated, I felt a distance between the work and the viewers. Perhaps due to its high theoretical nature. There was a disconnect.



Summer 2025
The academic year ended.
Summer arrived.
And then many questions about my project flooded my mind.
What am I getting at?
How do I relate to the topic?
And then, as a way to stop the flood of questions, I decided to focus on self-censorship, since it's the aspect of censorship I could most relate to.
Later, closer to the start of the 2nd year, I decided to focus on the intersection between self-censorship and graphic design.
Unsure of how to communicate this.



September 2025

The 2nd year started, and I wasn't sure how to do this. I felt like one year wasn't enough for exploring self-censorship and graphic design. But I challenged myself to do 30 posters on a 30-dayish timeline, as a way to map self-censorship's intersection with graphic design, as well as exploring the possible visual expression of this.

I started questioning myself about a final format for the project. I went to Kontfack's library searching for an answer to this inquiry. I found myself drawn to small formats, compact, pocketable. Contrasting with the references I had found last year, large, coffee-table-looking books (not in content but form). Even though I had imagined publications as an art form, something fragile and unique, this didn't seem like the right approach for this project, as I wanted this research to be easily available. Therefore, I was drawn to the idea of a reader, or a kind of reader. A term used for many graphic design research-based publications, that usually exist in a pocketable size.

My ultimate reference from the pile of books I picked up was "Glossary of Undisciplined Design", a contribution-based publication edited by Anja Kaiser and Rebecca Stephany. It was important to note that this reader was

not the sole focus of the project. It worked as a way to more easily document and share the project.
At first, I thought it would only include the "framework chapters", Understanding Self-censorship (or glossary of self-censorship? working title), Me, Myself and I as censor, and the final chapter framing the connection between self-censorship and graphic design. However, I concluded that the visual playground should also be documented for the reader. So the reader had access to as much of the project as possible in order to grasp it. Until then, I had planned a somewhat strict, controlled format.



11 x 17.5 cm softcover

Which usually was something I tended to avoid in my practice. But the project lived beyond these lines in the Visual Playground. In this section, I intended to let the rules of form go. The first visual playground worked as a conversation between posters that censored themselves. For 30 days, 30 iterations in an A3 format. I hoped to find an interesting and relevant answer to my research question, "How to make self-censorship visible?" through these visual conversations.

During one day about Typography, while listening to the research being developed, I figured it out. I made a poster where the content stayed the same. But the visual language mutated. The poster read something like "Come see this poster mutate through self-censorship", and then location and date. The exhibition encased 30 posters all stating this and reflecting on different aspects of self-censorship in the design process. The poster acted as a research experiment inquiring if I was actually able to somehow visualise self-censorship in the graphic design process. And the content functioned as an almost marketeer meta provocation.

I had also been thinking of the "Me, Myself and I as Censor" chapter. I had always had a hard time with vulnerability in my work, and I

loved to read auto-fiction. My author of choice was usually McKenzie Wark. And I had been reading her email correspondence with fellow auto-fiction writer Kathy Acker. Their way of sharing through email correspondence and auto-fiction might not have been exactly what I wanted to do. However, I wanted to find a similar structure that let my vulnerability free within my own rules.



Part of my process this week was also dealing with this norm creative desk (it's fixed now, as the amazing technicians helped. Documenting because it makes me laugh every time :)

October 2025

30 Days of Posters?

So I started making the posters. A week into making these posters, I made four, not seven. I realised that daily production is utopian and ignores external factors of life, as weekends are important for rest. While still aiming for 30 posters, this idea of strict daily production won't be part of it: Some days I might have produced three posters, while on the next two days I made none. Even if I didn't end up with 30, it wouldn't take away from the process, it's just a round number.

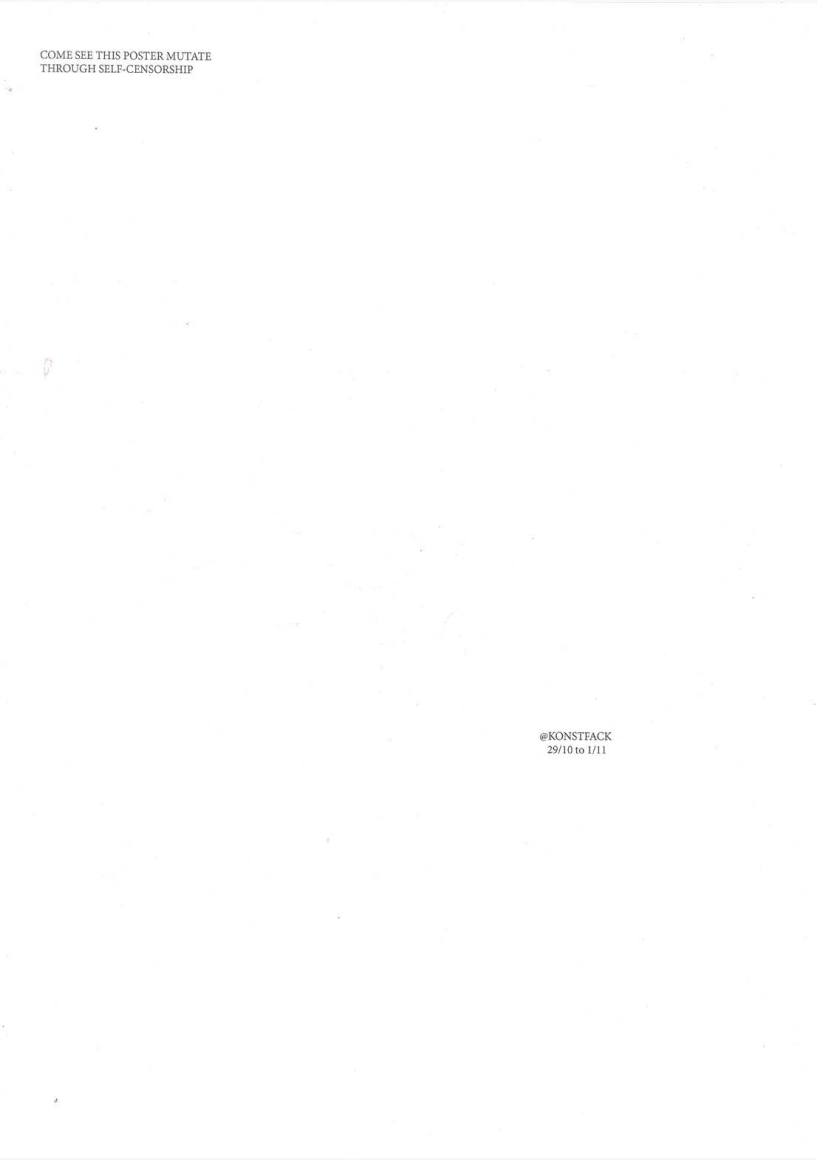


These 30 posters repeat the sentence "Come see this poster mutate through self-censorship @ Konstfack 29/10–1/11". Yet each one transforms through a different visual expression. Each mutation stems from a reflection, personal or collective, on the relationship between self-censorship and graphic design.
Hoping to answer the question "How to make self-censorship visible?

01 Poster

Default

In this first poster, I search for self-censorship within the default. I opened my design software of choice (Adobe InDesign) and set the text to the default font, Minion Pro Regular, 12pt, leading 14.4pt. Could the default itself be an answer? A viable visual communication choice?
The default, while being unconsidered, can be an answer, and I will start considering it as an option.
Here, I conclude that somehow self-censorship can exist within the choices we negate as viable without much consideration.



(scan of poster)

02 Poster

Softwares

Through this poster, I reflect on design software, negating the industry standard tools such as Adobe. Where subscription models rule, exploiting the financial situation of a not-so-well remunerated profession. Therefore, for this poster, I took it upon myself to forget the design tools imposed and go back to my first-ever design tool, The Sims, a one-time purchase tool. Here, I point out how our education and most of the information available for graphic designers might influence our choice in software.

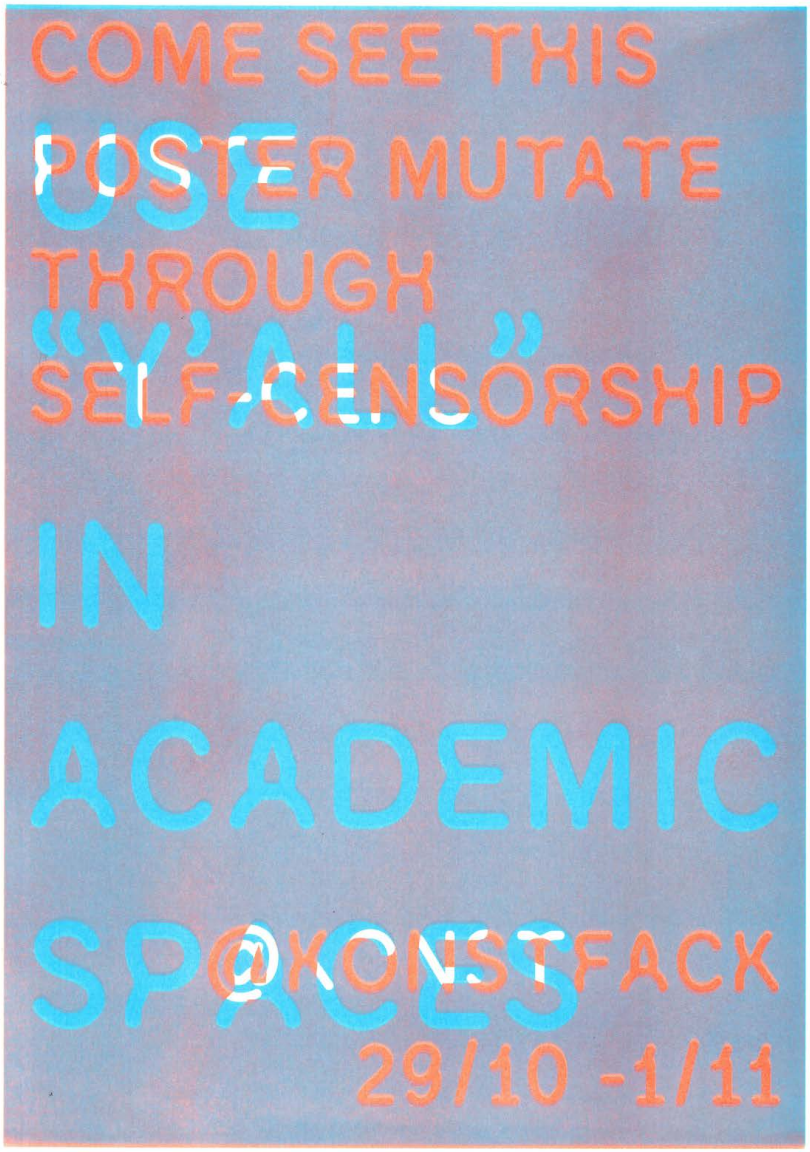
I remember at the start of my BA, dismissing those who used Canva. This took me a long time to unlearn. However, I've realised the programmes we use don't make our work inherently better. Here, I search for the self-censorship embedded in our reliance on exploitative software we use to design.



(scan of poster)

03 Poster

Y'all?
In this poster, I reflect upon what we choose to communicate through words. Recognising that in our practice, there are days when we don't want to communicate what is asked of us. The day I made this poster, I was thinking about a book I've been reading, Wordslut by Amanda Montell, where the author defends the use of the expression "y'all" as the best way to express the plural form of the second person, as the least patriarchal form. As my native language, Portuguese, has an established form for the second plural person, I've been searching for an answer myself while trying to stop using "you guys". Therefore, it's both a call to myself and to others. Ironically or not, I almost didn't make this poster. Only when a classmate called out that I was self-censoring, as I was dismissing this as "too much" or "not enough".
This moment and poster reflect self-censorship in its rawest, most recognisable form, to say or not to say what's on your mind.



(scan of poster)

04 Poster

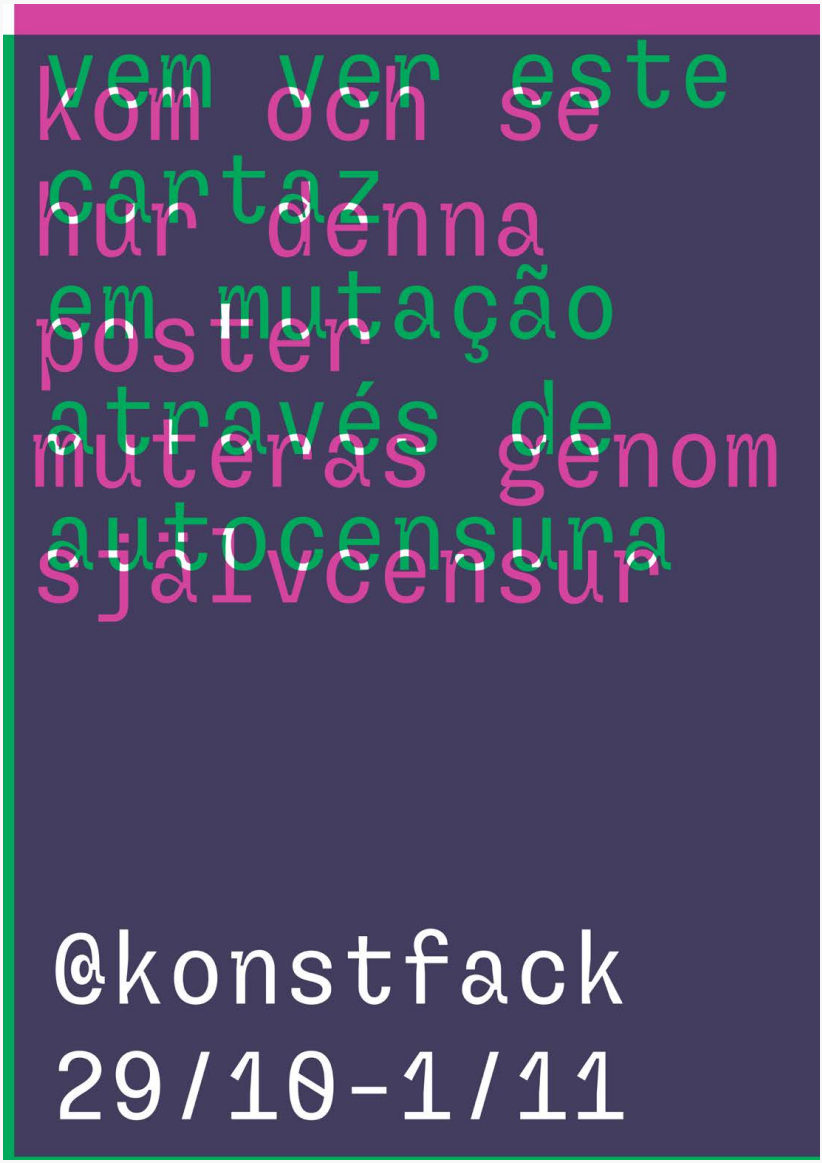
Bad type
This poster reflects on what we consider quality in typography. Questioning its relevance and power.
To do so, I used typefaces sourced from the website “https://www.dafont.com”, a website dismissed as lowbrow in the design community. By working with these typefaces, I search for an expression that reclaims their value. By naming the typefaces and type designers in the bottom left corner, I try to give visibility where it’s often missing. Here, self-censorship emerges through inherited notions of quality in design.



(scan of poster)

05 Poster

Autocensura/Självcensur
In this poster, I reference the overuse of English in graphic design circles. Increasingly, I notice visual communication in English even when addressing non-English speaking audiences. This unveils a quiet form of self-censorship where designers adapt their language to align with globalization, possibly not reaching the audience it's intended for. Therefore, in this poster, the absence of English stands as a reflection about how we might silence our own linguistic and cultural contexts in the pursuit of visibility on a mass global scale.


vem ver este cartaz
kom och se denna poster
em mutação
genom
genom
genom

06 Poster

Words?!
This poster regards how writing is a hidden part of a graphic designer's practice. While existing between words, images, and intentions.
Does the word mutate fully communicate the intention of this poster series? While the word "change" seems too simplistic to communicate my intentions. The word "reiterate" too much. The word "mutate" feels like a good compromise between the two.
When holding a critical graphic design practice, writing becomes a powerful tool, transcending visual communication.

come see
this poster
mutate
through
self-censorship

reiterate
change

@konstfack
29/10-1/11

(digital version/not printed yet)

07 Poster

Disillusions

This poster responds to a feeling that is at times overwhelming, questioning the importance, impact, and relevance of my own work. What are the actual consequences of this practice in the world? Surely, critical design might have a positive impact on the world,through awareness and reflection, but it's easy to dismiss it as not truly effective and consequential. These doubts act as a kind of censor in my practice. So while being aware of them, I accept that graphic design won't change the world, nor will my practice. However, it can still have a positive impact.


COME SEE
GRAPHIC
THIS POSTER
DESIGN
MUTATE
WON'T SAVE
THROUGH
THE WORLD
SELF-
NOR WILL
CENSORSHIP
THIS POSTER
@KONSTFACK
29/10-1/11

08 Poster

Morals/Survival
This poster reflects on the conflict between graphic design as a practice that pays the bills and job offers that don’t reflect your morals. When your economic livelihood is on the line, it becomes difficult to refuse work that contradicts your values. It also underlines socioeconomic positions, as someone from a higher economic standpoint might afford to respect their morals in their practice more easily. This tension creates an inner censorial system between what you believe in and what you agree to design for. As a negotiation between integrity and necessity.

COME SEE THIS POSTER MUTATE THROUGH SELF-CENSORSHIP

all I wanted was a freelance gig.

all I got was an offer from an AI company...

now i'm jobless and they probably will use AI for their logo.

@KONSTFACK

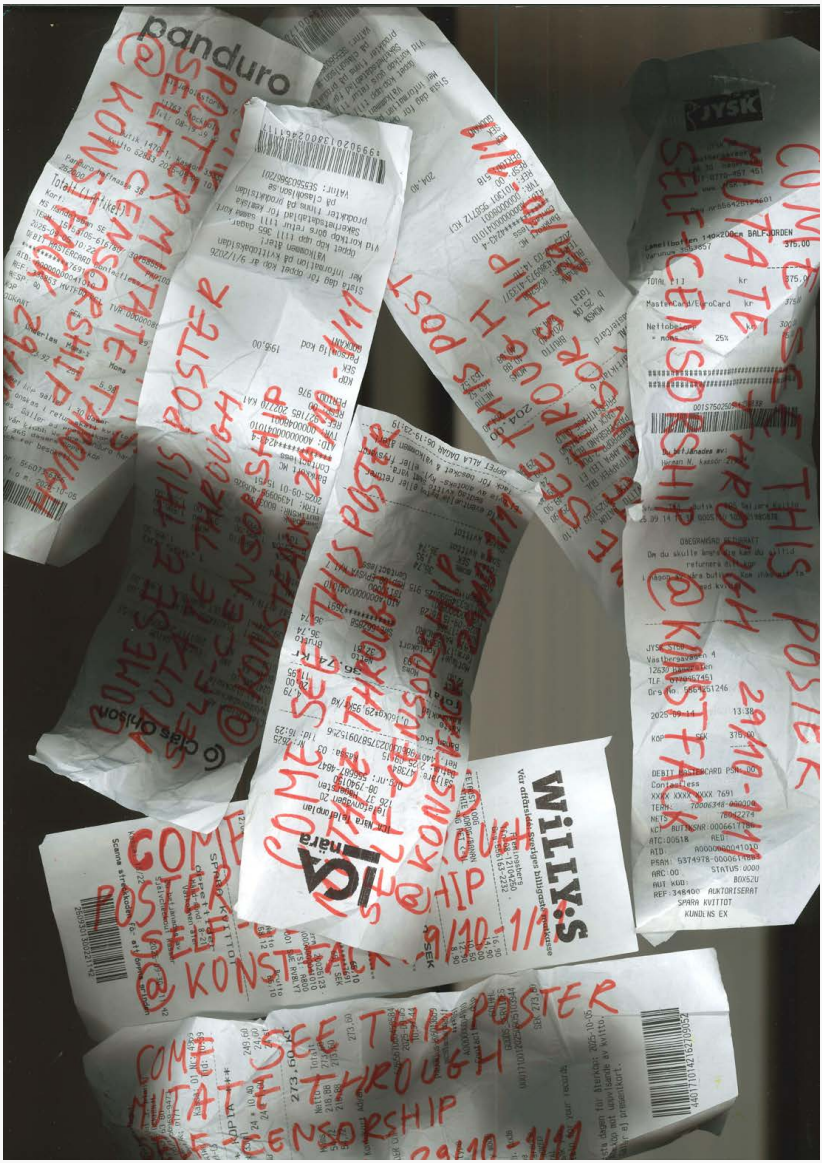
29/10 -1/11

09 Poster

Make the logo bigger
This poster reflects on moments in graphic design practice where expertise is questioned. Everyone engages with visual communication in some way, even unconsciously, placing its practice in a vulnerable position. When faced by external pressures, such as clients, the designer has to edit their visual choices, compromising the quality of their own work. Becoming a subtle form of self-censorship, where decisions are adjusted not for expression or communication but for compliance.

10 Poster

Can I afford to be critical?
This has been on my mind after reading the book.
Who can afford to be critical? by Afonso Matos. Criticality is often a luxury. As the cost of living rises and post-graduate life begins, the academic bubble of critical design quickly dissipates. Self-censorship here doesn't emerge from fear of judgment, but from economic constraints (even from a privileged position). It is shaped by the practical limits that determine what can be created and at what cost.


panduro
JYSK
WiLiX:S
COME SEE THIS POSTER
@KONSTFACK
SELFCENSORSHIP
THROUGH
29/10-1/11

11 Poster

Feeling grey
Evaluates how the designer’s life, mood, and emotions might affect their practice, decisions, and graphic expression. Here, the emotional politics of the graphic design practice are highlighted. Creative practices are particularly affected by external and personal factors.
Are the effects of our emotions in our visual choices unconscious? Or do we suppress them to keep professionalism?

COME SEE THIS POSTER MUTATE THROUGH SELF-CENSORSHIP

@KONSTFACK
29/10.1/11

12 Poster

Cringe?
Along the way of making these posters, I've found myself self-censoring due to being afraid of being cringe.
I use typefaces and gradients that might make me think I might be cringe, typefaces I overused in my early design days, and blotchy gradients. This fear of being perceived as cringe has grown in the last couple of years, strongly connected to internet spaces. However, personally, it has passed on to other social situations and even my graphic design practice.

COME SEE THIS
POSTER MUTATE
THROUGH
SELF-CENSORHSIP



@KONSTFACK
29/10-1/11

13 Poster

Cost of type
Typefaces are usually seen as decisions, but many forget how the cost of them is a big factor in their choice. While highlighting how the cost of typefaces might influence design choices, straying beyond purely aesthetic decisions. It shows how the financial dimension of a project directly influences visual choices in typography. It is important to be transparent about this, as well as to include these economic factors in graphic design education.

ITC Franklin Gothic Std Book

COME SEE THIS POSTER MUTATE
THROUGH SELF-CENSORSHIP
@KONSTFACK
29/10 to 1/11

ITC Franklin Gothic Std Book Italic

COME SEE THIS POSTER MUTATE
THROUGH SELF-CENSORSHIP
@KONSTFACK
29/10 to 1/11

COME SEE THIS POSTER
MUTATE
THROUGH SELF-CENSORSHIP
@KONSTFACK
29/10 to 1/11

COME SEE THIS POSTER MUTATE
THROUGH SELF-CENSORSHIP
@KONSTFACK
29/10 to 1/11

User
227 fonts

14 Poster

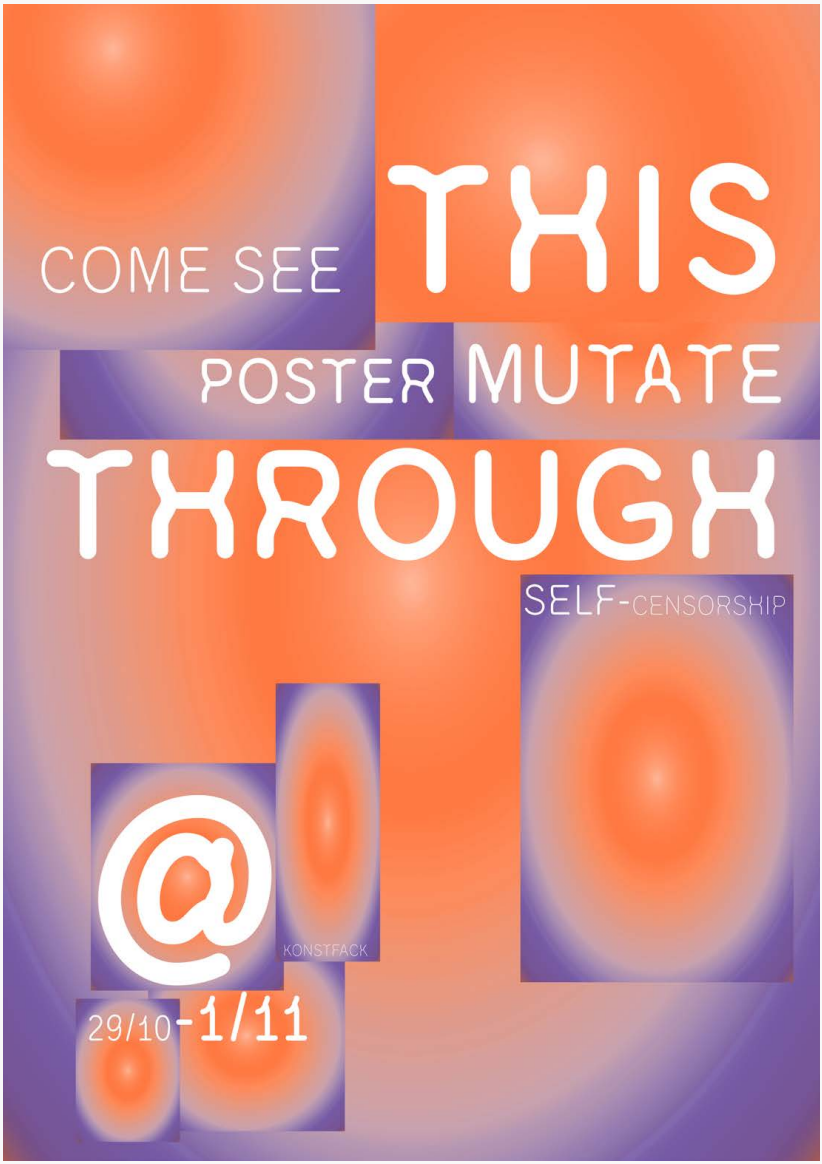
Choice

Examines how the abundance of typefaces influences design decisions. Does too much choice become its own constraint? I have 586 typefaces installed in my laptop, yet I keep using the same 10 typefaces time and time again. Along this poster series, you can identify the reuse of the same typefaces. The overwhelming amount of choice makes me rely on the same typefaces.

Come see this poster mutate through self-censorship @konstfack 29/10-1/11 Come see this poster mutate through self-censorship @

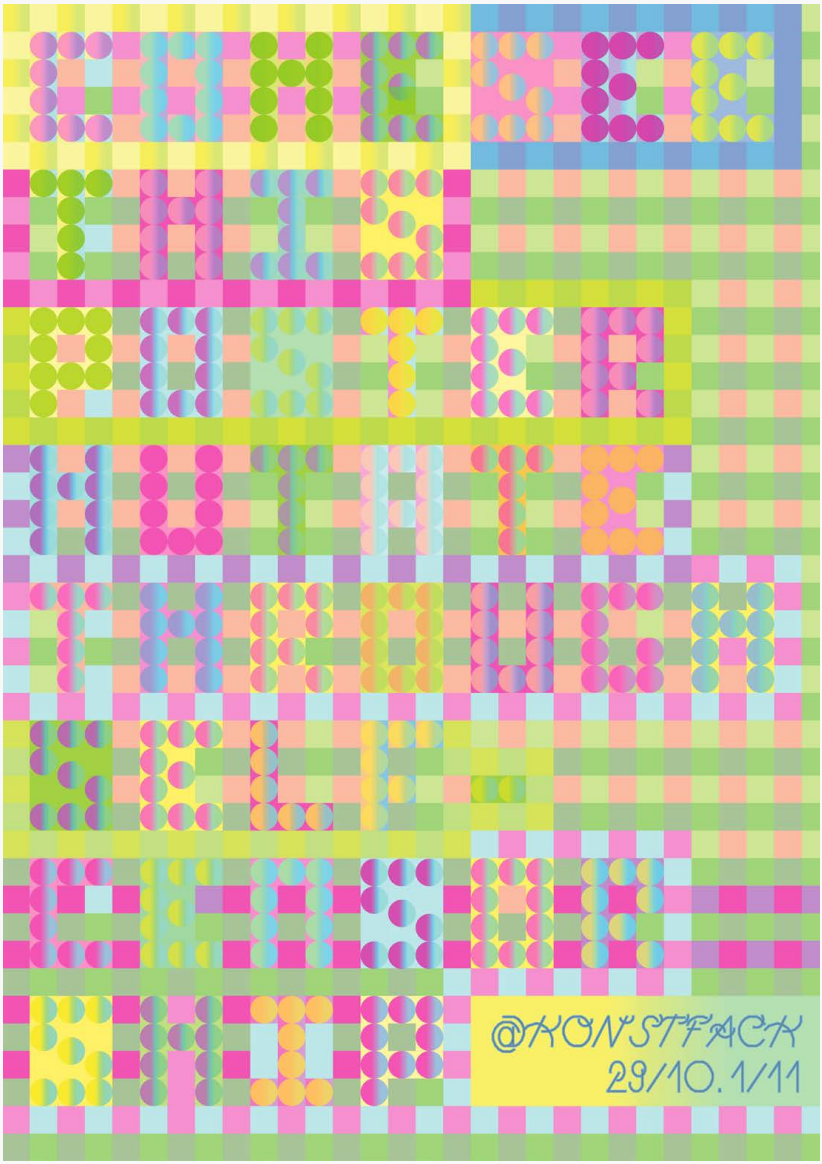
15 Poster

Hierarchies
Questions how visual and institutional hierarchies might shape a designer’s decisions and affect their sense of agency. By reversing hierarchies in this poster, I question who decides visual hierarchy.
While also provoking a reflection about power structures within graphic designers, senior, junior, intern, and student.


COME SEE
THIS
POSTER
MUTATE
THROUGH
SELF-CENSORSHIP
@
KONSTFACK
29/10-1/11

16 Poster

Style
Examines how the pressure to stick to a particular graphic style can become limiting. This particular graphic expression I usually don’t use in my primary practices. However, I am questioned why I don’t make this my primary style. The cost of limiting your practice to one specific graphic style also limits the scope of your communication and creative freedom.


@KONSTFACK
29/10.1/11

17, 18, 19, 20 Posters

Generator
This poster takes away choice as much as possible. Typeface, font weight, text alignment, placement, and colours were all picked by random online generators.
In a way, designing without any actual designing or choice making. Initially, it seemed like a complete ultimate self-censorer. As choice is taken away. However, the parameters made for these random choices create a particular graphic style. And reveal that there was, in fact, a choice in the process.


@Konstfack
29/10 to 1/11
Come see this poster mutate through self-censorship


@KONSTFACK
29/10 to 1/11
COME SEE THIS POSTER MUTATE THROUGH SELF-CENSORSHIP


@KONSTFACK
29/10 to 1/11
COME SEE THIS POSTER MUTATE THROUGH SELF CENSORSHIP


@KONSTFACK
29/10 to 1/11
COME SEE THIS POSTER MUTATE THROUGH SELF-CENSORSHIP

21 Poster

Instructions for a poster
Building on the last posters, it reveals the system, constraints, and rules to create a poster. Revealing how there was, in fact, a structural system designed for these posters.

instructions for a poster

set an A3 document (yes A3)

randomize

1. a background colour

https://mdigi.tools/random-color/#google_vignette

google "random number" (if word atributte numbers in respective order)

2. (see how many you have on your font book and set that number to max)
2.1. (I usually use 150pts as max so it fits but this can be adjusted due text)
2.2. alignleft/aligncentre/alignright/justifyleft/justifycentre/justifyright

2. a typeface
2.1. weight
2.2. justification/alignment
2.3. uppercase/lowercase
2.4. "box" size (w,h)
2.5. placement (x,y)
2.6. colour

3.1. same typeface (yes/no)
3.1.1. if no randomize typeface
3.2. same weight (yes/no)
3.2.1. if no randomize weight
3.3. justification/alignment
3.4. uppercase/lowercase
3.5. "box" size (w,h)
3.6. placement (x,y)
3.7. same colour (yes/no)
3.7.1. if no randomize colour

COME SEE THIS POSTER
MUTATE THROUGH
SELF-CENSORSHIP
@konstfack
29/10.1/11

you have a poster

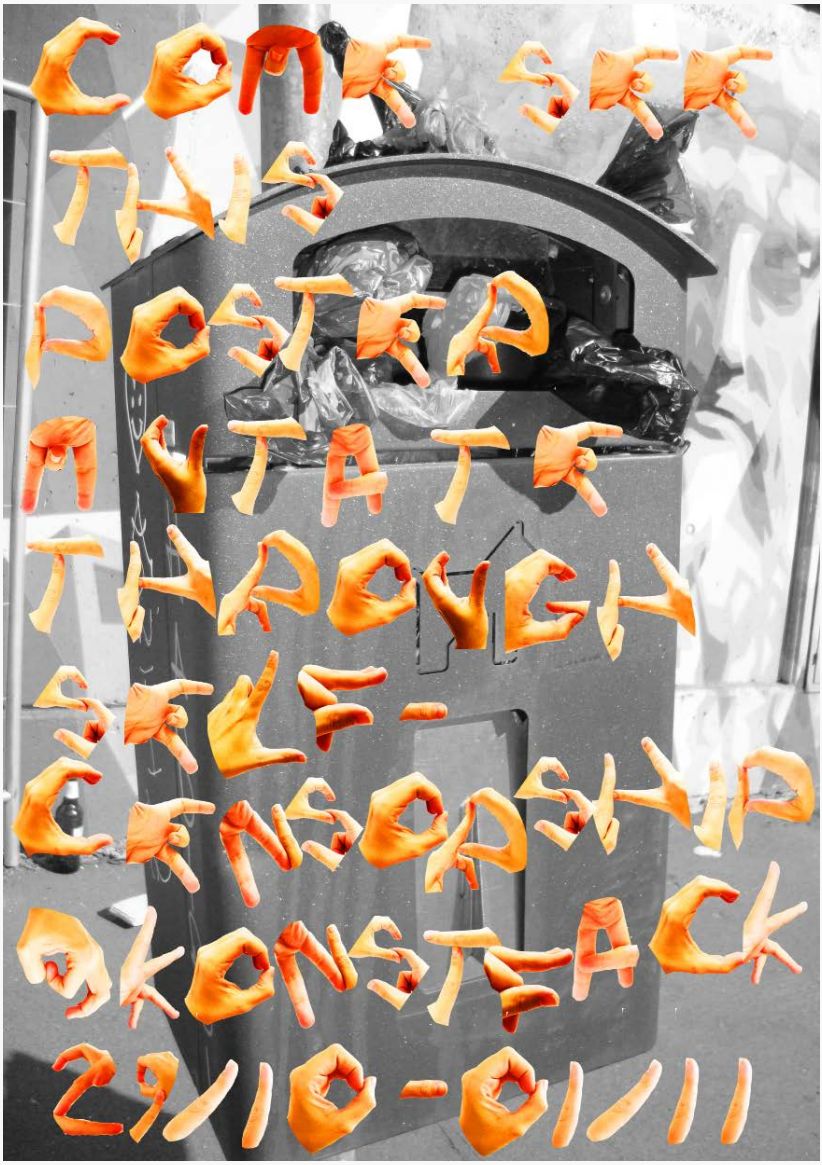
22 Poster

Scan for infinite posters
Redirects to a website coded with the rules of the previous posters, generating infinite variations using p5.js.I decided to code the instructions seen on poster 21 using creative coding through p5.js and coding languages Java and HTML.
Transformed it into a website under https://relaxed-bonbon-b0309c.netlify.app



23 Poster

Do something by hand
Those around me have been challenging me to make a poster by hand for this series. I have tried and was never happy with the result.
This is my response to this. I use my hands typographically in a digital way.
Responds to the challenge of making a poster by hand. Here, hands are used typographically in a digital way, bridging manual gestures and digital expression.


COME SEE
THIS
POSTER
MUTATE
THROUGH
SELF-
CENSORSHIP
AKONSTEACK
29/10-01/11

24 Poster

Design Rules

Questions design rules such as stroke on type, slanted text, repetition, and hierarchies. Breaking the rules of what you are taught that you can or cannot do in graphic design and making them evident.

come see this poster mutate through self-censorship

@konstfack
29/10.1/11

25 Poster

Can someone choose for me
Reflects on decision fatigue in design. Too many choices can lead to surrendering authorship. As it is poster number 25, it also reveals that this decision fatigue can come from pressure to produce in mass quantities, becoming overwhelming to take part in your own practice.


Come see this poster
mutate through
self-censorship
@Konstfack
29.10-1.11
Come see this poster
mutate through
self-censorship
@Konstfack
29.10–1.11
Ballot Bin™

26 Poster

Overwhelmed
Considers the mental and digital clutter of the design process, overwhelming deadlines, and open tabs. Reflecting upon how overstimulation and pressure can lead to a lack of clarity and getting lost in the process.


Come see this poster mutate through self-
Come see this poster mutate through self-censorship
@Konstfack
29 Oct 2025 to 1 Nov 2025
you who reads this
Add Notes or Attachments
come see this poster mutate through self-ce
Filenames
Name matches: come see this poster mutate thr...

27 Poster

I didn’t want this to become about me
Evaluates how not wanting to make your work too personal can make it insincere, while acknowledging the importance of maintaining privacy and boundaries.
At the beginning of this master’s, I thought a lot about how I didn’t want the project to be about myself. This fear often affects my creativity. It really feels like the factor that makes me self-censor the most. Therefore, this series tries to let go of that as much as possible.

COME SEE THIS POSTER MUTATE THROUGH SELF-CENSORSHIP



@KONSTFACK
29/10 to 1/11



I didn't want this to become about me



28 Poster

Body as type
Building on the fear of revealing too much of yourself in your work, using my body as letterforms. Here, I put myself in the centre of the design, making it undeniable that I am part of it. As a way of trying to let go of this censor.

COME SEE
THIS POSTER
MUTATE
THROUGH
SELF-
CENSORSHIP
@KONSTFACK
29/10-01/11

29 Poster

Handwritten
Continuing to build on the fear of self-revelation, the use of handwriting stands as one of the most personal visual expressions of yourself.

Come
see this
poster
mutate
through
Self-
Censorship
@ Komstack
29/10-1/11

30 Poster

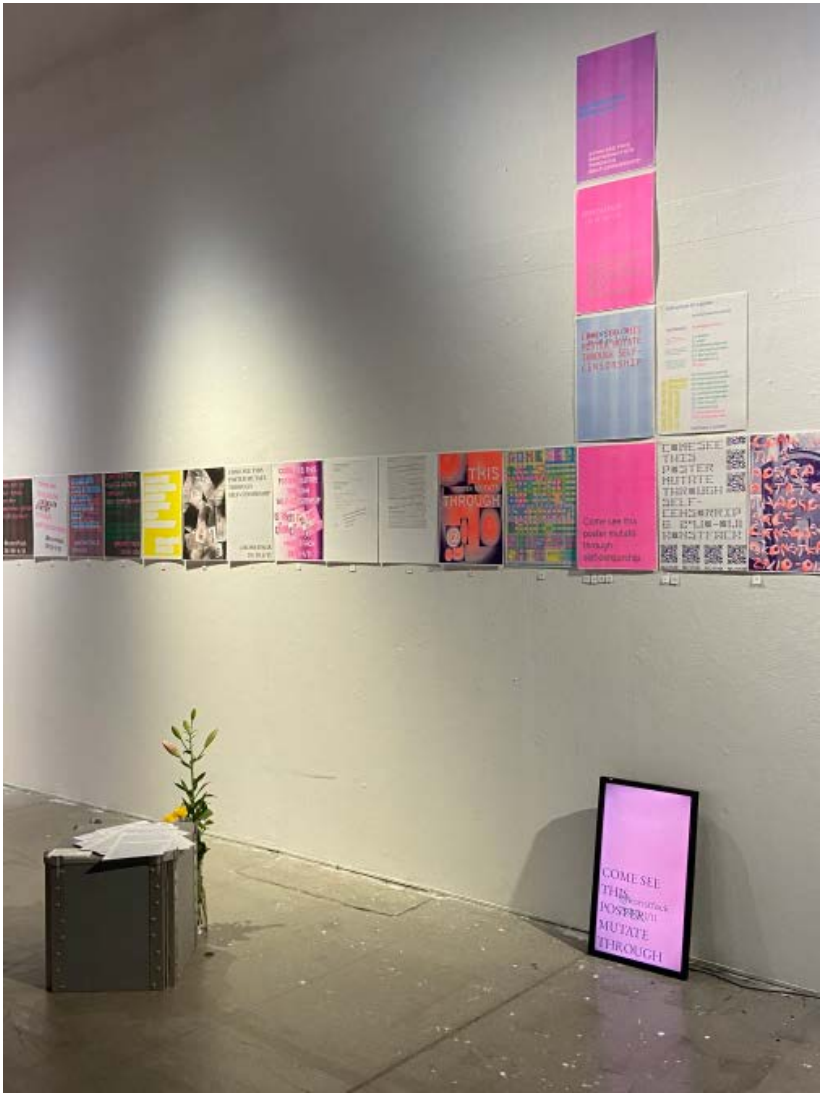
It’s all about me
At last, I accept that work is personal, and that the self is relevant to both the process and the result while putting myself in the centre of my work.


COME SEE THIS
POSTER MUTATE
THROUGH SELF-
CENSORSHIP
instructions for a poster
randomize
1. a background colour
2. a typeface
2.1. weight
2.2. justification/alignmer
2.3. uppercase/lowercas
2.4. "box" size (w,h)
2.5. placement (x,y)
2.6. colour
3.1. same typeface (yes/n
3.1.1. if no randomize type
3.2. same weight (yes/no
3.2.1. if no randomize wei
3.3. justification/alignme
3.4. uppercase/lowercas
3.5. "box" size (w,h)
3.6. placement (x,y)
3.7. same colour (yes/no
3.7.1. if no randomize colo
you have a poste
COME SEE THIS POSTER MUTATE THROUGH SELF-CENSORSHIP @konstfack 29/10.1/11

29/10/2025–1/11/2025
Havet exhibition

One of the reasons I decided to create this poster series was the thought of filling up a big space like Havet. I wanted my section of the exhibition to be a walk-through of these 30 posters, a scroll through the reflections. Following the posters, along with a poster guide paper, where you could follow the posters and reflections simultaneously. At last, the TV showed the website https://relaxed-bonbon-b0309c.netlify.app.

I felt like the exhibition was a success. I feel like I have to narrow down what the relationship between graphic design and self-censorship is. Since some posters and respective reflections deviate from this intersection.


THIS
THROUGH
COME SEE
THIS
POSTER
MUTATE
THROUGH


Come see this poster mutate
through self-censorship
@NoiseFace 28/10-4/11

Post feedback reflections

Right before the exhibition, I had a meeting with my external tutor. Their feedback prevailed on the fact that my work has strayed from the topic of self-censorship.

During the exhibition, I also realised that the phrasing "Come see this poster mutate through self-censorship" didn't communicate well without an accompanying explanation. Some visitors seemed to be confused by its meaning.

At the feedback session, someone who had previously seen the posters around Södermalm shared that they struggled to understand what the poster meant. After trying to interpret it, they associated self-censorship with the far right. This made me realise that my message can be easily lost without context. Throughout the feedback, it was also highlighted several times that the pedagogical quality of the poster series was especially amongst non-designers. They shared that the series taught them not only about the graphic design practice, but also about the possible expressions of type and graphic design.

At last, what struck me most was the feedback that I seemed to be censoring myself throughout the series by not directly communicating any of my political stances.

Now I have to reflect on what this means for the project. The message is somehow lost, the poster form seemed to work, as well as the visual elements. What was really lost was within the repeating message. I didn't think this message was so central. It was more of a means for my reflection. But it clearly is central to the public when they see my posters.
The poster series was thought of as a chapter in my final publication, not as the whole project. I'm interested in how it might work within the context of my final publication. However, I would feel more confident if the poster series worked better on its own. I might edit it.
The pedagogical tone of my work is something I would like to conserve throughout the project. The lack of political stances in the project is also a concern for me, as I understand that we cannot talk about self-censorship without being political. However, delving more into political stances feels like an aggravating factor for my topic dispersion.
This has helped me frame my project further as I see that my work is about where self begins and practice ends, and how self-censorship affects that boundary.

Creating my working title and subtitle:

Where self begins and practice ends:
Notes on self-censorship in graphic design

Had a meeting with my external tutor that helped me fully digest the feedback and understand where to go. The poster form makes sense, and the repetition with "interventions" also communicates. What communicates poorly is the repeating phrase "come see this poster mutate through self-censorship @konstfack." it might have worked for the exhibition, but doesn't fully work for the project itself. Therefore, it might be helpful to re-edit the posters, maintaining reflections and visual expression. However, changing the repeating message! To what? I don't know yet! We also talked about having the poster form as the core of my publication, due to the challenge of finding texts outside a theoretical/academic sphere. It could be a useful way to communicate theory in an approachable way. Furthermore, we also pinpointed why the phrase doesn't work by talking about the concept of ornamental politics, a concept created by Silvio Lorusso: "Politics acquires a decorative value, it becomes

ornamental politics: the radical slogan, the activist posture," and this phrase could be misinterpreted and considered ornamental politics due to its lack of clarity. Clarifying that these posters should be operative and not self-proclaimed as reflections on self-censorship. Provoking my audience to reflect on self-censorship.

I also identified that I want to keep working with the poster form due to its power in public spaces. (Based on my experiences postering around Stockholm, etc.)

I also don't want to erase the idea of mapping, though. But the idea of having the posters as a publication feels more powerful than a traditional publication structure that I was building with chapters, etc. Even though I can create a narrative based on these chapters, with the poster sequence. This also feels more tangible to me as existing in the digital realm.

Change, like the wind
Like the water, like skin
Change, like the sky
Like the leaves, like a butterfly

– Lyrics from Change by Big Thief

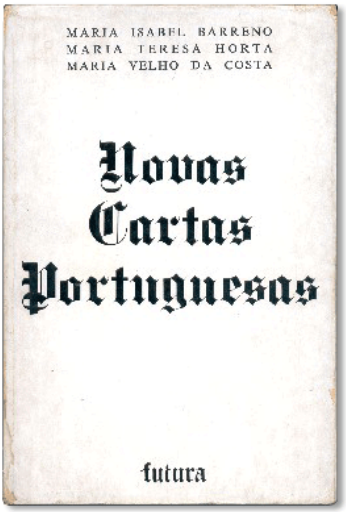
November 2025

I've felt as if I've hit a turning point in my project. After the poster series and its final exhibition, I felt a desire to turn back. To the very beginning of November 2023, when I first wrote a project proposal that has evolved into my master's project. The same proposal I submitted for my declaration of intent in January 2024.

'Erasing Blue Pencil' is a project proposal driven by the question: What initiatives within the act of republishing can aid further acknowledgment toward historically censored publications? By republishing historically censored books and creating a collection to celebrate them. This is achieved through a redesign and visual interventions within the books. Starting with the collection 'Apagar lápis azul,' which consists of books censored during the Portuguese dictatorship. Censorship was done using a blue pencil, resulting in the name 'Erasing Blue Pencil.' The rubber and its wrapper are provocative elements serving as a project proposal.

This was one of the first drafts of this. Also, the first moments of contemplating censorship in my practice. Heavily influenced by the (at the time) upcoming 50th anniversary of the Carnation Revolution, April 25, 2024.

I decided to give it a try. Redesigning/ republishing censored books.
From the start, there was a book I knew I wanted to republish, "Novas Cartas Portuguesas". So I started designing around one of the letters.
And I found a new excitement in my project that I hadn't felt in some time. This made me make the switch in my project to refocus on republishing censored publications.



Engaging with this book has created an engaging dialogue with my mom, a Portuguese teacher whose knowledge of this and other censored books provides deeper historical context and significance to my own research process.

Not disregarding the project that maps self-censorship's relation to graphic design, as it allowed me to be more vulnerable and challenged my fear of making my own work about myself. But rather than letting that

project grow with time without the pressure of it being my master's thesis.
Rather, I will focus on a project that has had the time to mature through the years.

Current Research Question

How can visual communication honour censored books through visual expression, ornament, and care?

I want to do a collection of re-editions of books that were censored either in the present or the past. Where the visual language deviates from commercial book design, it values the use of colour, ornament, and thoughtful graphic decisions in order to honour these texts.
Many of these books are still under copyright, so I'm not actually republishing them. These books are non-commercial design studies that explore how they might be visually reimagined. The work respects legal limits, acknowledges the original authors and publishers, and stays transparent about its status as an academic prototype rather than an actual reissue.
The books I'm considering share the fact that they were censored because they challenged dominant systems. I'm focusing on feminist perspectives, queer stories, resistant writings, and decolonial voices as these are part of the narratives that censorship consistently targets historically and today, and also themes

that speak to me. Language also plays a role. I'm working with books originally written in Portuguese and English.

Why Ornament, Colour, and Care

I'm focusing on visual expression, colour, and ornament because they have historically been suppressed under authoritarian regimes. These regimes tend to favour uniformity, clarity, and controlled communication. Bringing ornament and colour into these books is a way of working against the visual logic of censorship itself. Ornament and colour have also been repeatedly dismissed as excessive, feminine, or unnecessary attitudes that mirror how many of the voices in these censored books were treated. So using ornament here becomes intentional: a way to value what was historically devalued, and to create space for complexity, care, and expression.

Care, time, and deliberate decisions are important here because censorship is fundamentally about oppression. So the process of republishing becomes an act of repair. By spending time with these books, researching their contexts, selecting typefaces, developing ornaments, and crafting physical details, I want a form of visual care. This labour becomes a way of honouring the

authors, the histories, and the people who put themselves at risk by writing these texts.

Case Study: Novas Cartas Portuguesas

Out of this list, only Novas Cartas Portuguesas is definitive.

"Novas Cartas Portuguesas" by Maria Isabel Barreno, Maria Teresa Horta and Maria Velho da Costa.

"Novas Cartas Portuguesas", or "New Portuguese Letters", was published in 1972 by Maria Velho da Costa, Maria Teresa Horta, and Maria Isabel Barreno, known as the Three Marias. The book challenged the Estado Novo dictatorship through feminist writing that mixed poetry, prose, testimony, and political critique.

The book was first published in Portugal and censored three days later. Shortly after, the authors were arrested and charged with "offending public morals" and "attacking the state." However, they managed for the book to arrive in Paris in the hands of Simone de Beauvoir and many other influential feminist writers who pushed for the international publication of the book.

Their trial became one of the most important feminist cases of the 20th century, gathering international solidarity and exposing the brutality of the regime. Some say the book was

influential in taking down the regime.
It is, however, not read by that many in Portugal. As I had this conversation with my mom recently about it she is a Portuguese teacher in a school with one of the biggest and historical libraries in Portuguese public schools, yet there was not a single copy of Novas Cartas Portuguesas. It was quite shocking and surprising to me. It's clearly still disregarded and stigmatised.
Republishing it today is a way of revisiting a text that was revolutionary, and recognising its continued relevance in conversations about gender, body politics, and resistance.
Other Books I considered
The Color Purple by Alice Walker was censored many times and still is being censored in schools in the USA.
The books can be any genre, fiction, non-fiction, poetry, etc. I will mostly stay within Portuguese and English language books.

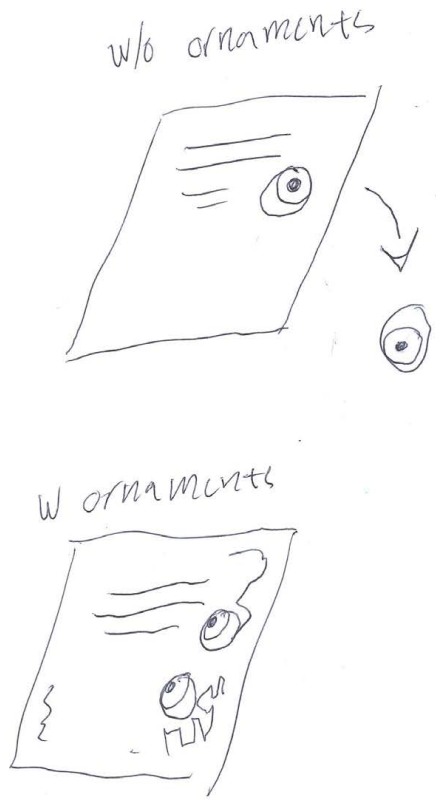
Visual Direction

For typographic research, I'm currently creating my own reference font list. For the body, all the books will share a typeface. And each book has a distinct display of contemporary open source typeface. Currently, I'm researching what ornament

would be relevant for Novas Cartas Portuguesas. I've been researching with my mom the visual legacy of the women in my family from the time of the dictatorship. And I have mainly found a strong legacy in textile and cross-stitch.
I have also been sketching how to translate this legacy into my own visual language.
I would like the books to manifest themselves in a physical object. For Novas Cartas Portuguesas, I plan to republish one of the letters in textile. I also plan to have small publications that act as manifestos for these editions.
I'd like it to go beyond the pages and exist in the borders by using fore-edge printing. Similarly, I'd also like for the sewn binding to create distinct patterns.
It's a challenge to complete this in practically a semester.

Feedback and stuff

Last feedback session Martina drew this.



January 2026

Winter break passed, and I understood why not to design/publish 3 books. First, they would be rushed. Secondly, I wouldn't have as much time to develop the publisher parallel to the book. And lastly, it contradicts the fact that I want to spend time with my books.

Therefore, for my MA project, I will present my small publisher of censored books and my first republishing as "Novas Cartas Portuguesas".

I will have two focuses that intersect. The publisher and the publication. I have thought a lot about the visual language. I am not completely confident in translating the cross-stitch expression into my book. Even though I'd like to keep the visual research of the women in my family present. I want to find a new way to translate them. My perspective on this republishing is to bring new light to a relevant publication censored more than 50 years ago. Therefore, I want these new eyes to align with my visual choices. Not to be stuck in the past.

I haven't had the courage to write a letter to introduce this republishing of the book. Many things run through my mind:

The Portuguese presidential elections had only one woman as a candidate out of eleven. A leading candidate accused of sexual assault, using this accusation to mediatise his own

campaign.
AI is continuously violating our human rights, and women are the centre of this (ex: Grok).
The new age of colonization.
The political weaponization of bodily autonomy.
All topics that deeply relate to “Novas Cartas Portuguesas”. How can I make this book be read now?
I searched for answers in visuals.
Colours, typography, and different types of visual expression.

Building something more: curating, network cold emails, and dialogue

How can this book be read now?

I've been thinking about making this project more about a present dialogue.
The "contemporary" that I'm seeking in the visuals could be translated into something more concrete in the project.

I felt like I was searching for something in the visuals that was missing elsewhere.

Then I had a talk with an external tutor, Nina Paim. She helped me to do this. Not a simple redesign. Something more that creates a deeper dialogue.

I started by writing my own response to a letter. It didn't feel that hard. But I knew I couldn't write it all. I reached out to my network. My great friend and writer Patrícia immediately said yes which was a moment of shared excitement. Then I further reached out to my network. And cold emailed* people with voices that could really compliment this project.

*cold emails are unsolicited, messages sent to a prospect with no prior relationship to initiate a conversation

Surprisingly, the first responses were from the cold emails. Very gratifying messages that made this project feel possible. One of them came from someone who already did this for a Portuguese magazine, yet they gave me the text and said I was free to republish. This created some turmoil. First, reminded me of the obvious reality that you were never inventing the wheel, this has been done, differently, but it has. I have overcome this thought, since I do see this project as something quite different from the magazine article.
A live archive in printed form of contemporary reflections on these letters, not something that was there to celebrate the 50 years of the book, less ephemeral, more continuous. It was also a bit of a wake-up call, I might be thinking of voices that already have a very established space. It could be interesting to welcome a more diverse group into this dialogue, established and non-established. The reflection will be the core of it. Another thing that this brought up was the prospect of republishing this text. Even though I was already republishing the 72 letters, that act is very intentional. The republishing of this text as a response didn't fit in quite as well into the project.

I thought of only inviting Portuguese writers, while I know so many amazing non-Portuguese speaking people that could write significant responses to these letters, the context of Portuguese history and culture is wildly relevant. This also brings up the language of the publication. The book's original language is Portuguese, and so am I, yet I'm presenting this in Stockholm, to a mostly non-Portuguese-speaking audience. Therefore, I have come to the realization that I need to have both languages. All of this brings a lot of work to these next months, and I won't be able to find replies to the 120 texts in the 1972 book. So I have selected a couple of more significant letters that resonate with our current reality. Yet I do see this as a live archive that could possibly grow with time.

Something else that also runs through my mind is how this project has changed, and it doesn't stop to do so, but it doesn't bother me anymore. I think about how perhaps the poster series has influenced this change. The reflections are some kind of dialogue. And this dialogue I'm creating with the book. Once I get back to typesetting the book for print, I will also reread the poster series to take these into account in my choices.

February 2026

At this point, I'm close to 10 voices and 10 letters. The process has been challenging, but I've learned that publishing is largely about conversation and decision-making. I've been discussing with my tutor how to handle the original 1971 letters. Should I try to negotiate the rights, or simply reference them? I'm leaning toward referencing them rather than republishing. What matters most are the contemporary reflections; if including the original letters compromises the project, I am willing to adjust.

Finding the 10 Voices

Gathering these texts was a "two-month-ish" process involving a lot of emails, really, too many emails. I began by calling a dear friend, Patrícia. Starting with someone I trusted and admired was a much-needed vote of confidence. From there, I branched out into my own network and my mother's. I asked friends for recommendations, and my mom called writer friends of her own; that's how Elisabete joined the project.

At one stage, I questioned my target group. Would it be only women? Only Portuguese adjacent voices? By the end of February, I had two voices confirmed, and I assigned each a

specific letter to reply to. This was a test of my curating practices, reading and rereading the 1971 book until I found the perfect pairing for each writer.

When it was time to reach out via "cold" emails to people whose work I admired, it was intimidating. I even scheduled the emails to be sent while I was busy, so I wouldn't have to press the "scary" send button myself. Leonor Rosas, whose feminist podcast Lei da Paridade I listen to religiously, was the first to reply. Her excitement made me beam and gave me the confidence to continue. More replies followed that first day, including one that left me with mixed feelings. An artist I admired replied that she had already written something similar. I was taken aback, had I not "invented the wheel"? Slowly, the collection grew robust with voices like Maria Giulia Pinheiro, Joana and Mariana (whom I video-called to simplify the process), and André Tecedeiro. I talked about the project so much with my mother that I eventually wanted her voice present, too. I also spent a week waiting on a "maybe" from a voice I valued deeply, but when it didn't turn into a "yes," I realized it was time to move forward with the strong collection I had built.

Translation

Translation was a whirlwind. Many hours. About a day per text to complete each translation. From Portuguese to English.

At first I translate it as a whole, leaving some words and expressions untranslated.

Then I take those words and expressions to Google Translate. However, some words, when translated, change the meaning of the text. Some words, when translated into English, lose their power. That's where footnotes come into play. While keeping some words in Portuguese. It's a process that's hard to explain. At times, I ask friends to review the translation, etc.

At last, when the translation and footnotes are done, I send them to the author of the respective text for them to review. One text that was particularly challenging was a poem. Poetry translation is particularly challenging and felt a bit like a crime, but the author gave a positive response to the translation, so I went with it.

Titles, titles, titles

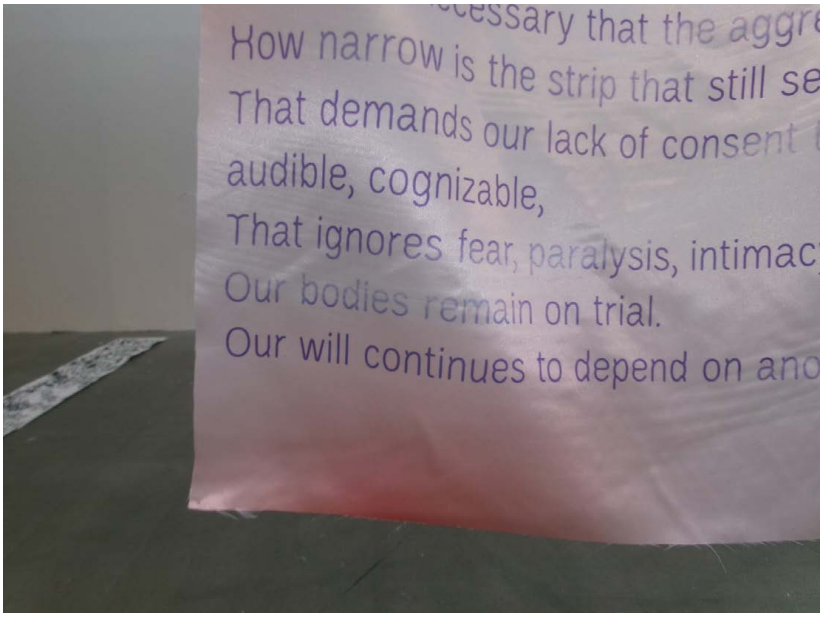
I've given this quite some thought. I'm quite sure about the subtitle being "New New Portuguese Letters". I have two days to decide since I need to submit my title for the exhibition soon. I started with "in 20 hands", I liked it at first, but I started feeling it was too literal and compromising, what if one of my writers fell through, and I don't end up with 20 hands? I want 20 hands to communicate collectivity, yet the many contributors on the book cover will show this. Therefore, the title isn't adding much. Then I thought of a slight shift to "In our hands: New New Portuguese Letters", yet, it could be read as if I was pressuring people to make change, saying it's in our hands as if we were totally in control, as if fascist states don't exist. So now I'd better think.

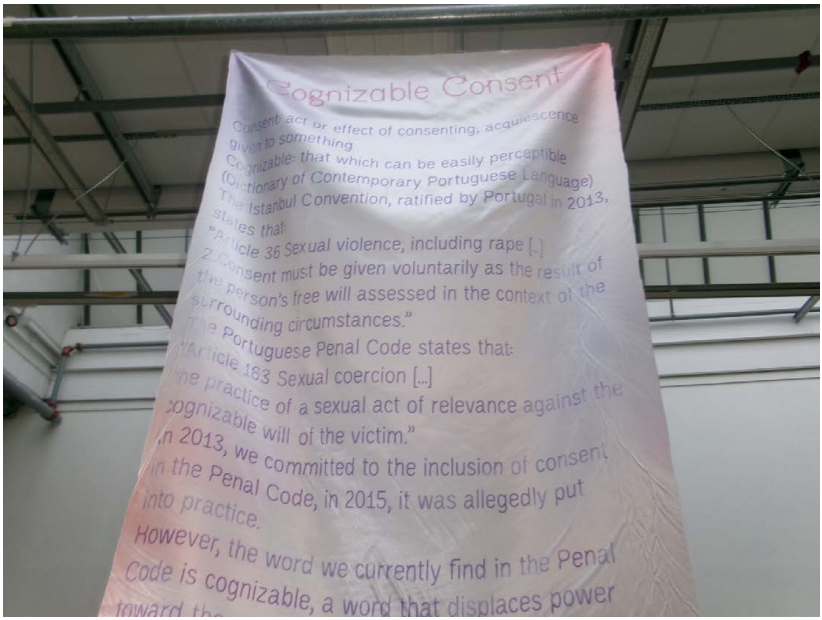
Yet I still like the backdrop of "In 20 Hands", "A 20 mãos", it's a common expression used in Portuguese when talking about a book that is written by more than one person, as well as I've read the New Portuguese Letters being referenced as written in six hands. Yet it loses its power with translation. I'm having a problem. The titles work better in Portuguese than English. I think I'll stick with "A 20 mãos/20 Hands: New New Portuguese letters".

Exhibition and Textiles

For the spring exhibition, I plan to have the 1971 book available in Portuguese, English, and Swedish to provide a framework for the new letters. I want the exhibition to act as a release, featuring a talk or a reading.

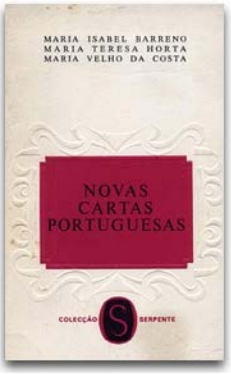
During the exhibition course with Farvarsh Razavi, I began exploring these texts through textiles. I enjoyed seeing the words at a large scale; it did something paper cannot. A paper publication is intimate and individual, it's rare for more than one person to look at a book at a time.
In textiles, however, a sense of collectiveness was brought to the display.

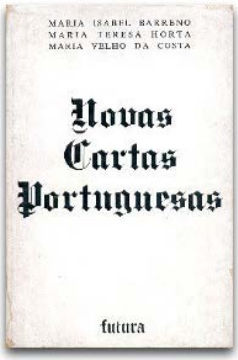

How narrow is the strip that still se
That demands our lack of consent
audible, cognizable,
That ignores fear, paralysis, intimac
Our bodies remain on trial.
Our will continues to depend on ano


Cognizable Consent
Consent: act or effect of consenting, acquiescence given to something
Cognizable: that which can be easily perceptible
(Dictionary of Contemporary Portuguese Language)
The Istanbul Convention, ratified by Portugal in 2013, states that:
"Article 36 Sexual violence, including rape [...]
2 Consent must be given voluntarily as the result of the person's free will assessed in the context of the surrounding circumstances."
The Portuguese Penal Code states that:
"Article 163 Sexual coercion [...]
the practice of a sexual act of relevance against the cognizable will of the victim."
In 2013, we committed to the inclusion of consent in the Penal Code, in 2015, it was allegedly put into practice.
However, the word we currently find in the Penal Code is cognizable, a word that displaces power

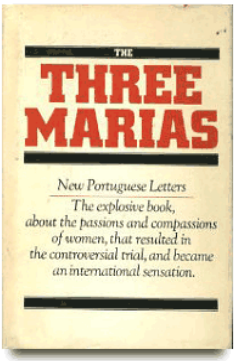
Archival Library

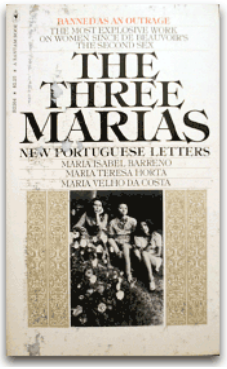
To establish the connection between the 1972 and 2026 letters, I compiled an archive of "New Portuguese Letters" books across many editions and languages. The priority was to have Portuguese, English, and Swedish versions. I ended up with eight editions. They were both important for the research process of the book and were present in the exhibition, creating a bridge between the two books.

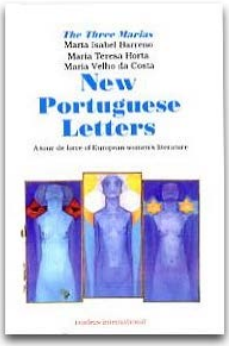

MARIA ISABEL BARRENO
MARIA TERESA HORTA
MARIA VELHO DA COSTA
NOVAS CARTAS PORTUGUESAS
COLECÇÃO S SERPENTE


MARIA ISABEL BARRENO
MARIA TERESA HORTA
MARIA VELHO DA COSTA
Novas Cartas Portuguesas
futura

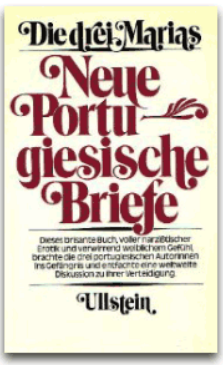

novas cartas portuguesas
Maria Isabel Barreno
Maria Teresa Horta
Maria Velho da Costa
Organização de Ana Luísa Amaral


THE
THREE MARIAS
New Portuguese Letters
The explosive book,
about the passions and compassions
of women, that resulted in
the controversial trial, and became
an international sensation.


BANNED AS AN OUTRAGE
THE MOST EXPLOSIVE WORK
ON WOMEN SINCE DE BEAUVOIR'S
THE SECOND SEX
THE THREE MARIAS
NEW PORTUGUESE LETTERS
MARIA ISABEL BARRENO
MARIA TERESA HORTA
MARIA VELHO DA COSTA

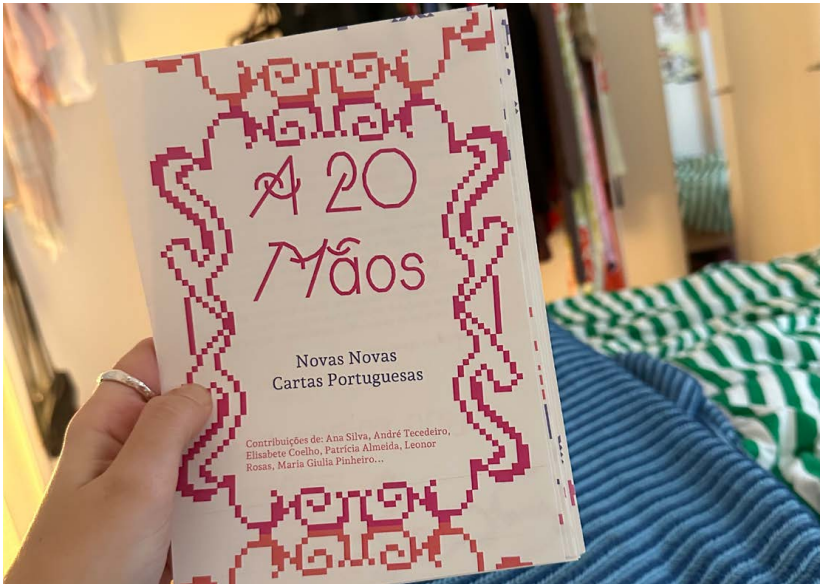

The Three Marias
Maria Isabel Barreno
Maria Teresa Horta
Maria Velho da Costa
New Portuguese Letters


De tre Mariornas bok.
NYA PORTUGISISKA BREV
FORUM


Die drei Marias
Neue Portugiesische Briefe
Ullstein

Finishing the book

The last couple of weeks before printing the book have been fast-paced, as expected. I've been doing everything simultaneously to make it easier. If I were doing one task at a time, it would have become boring. Finishing up translations. Contacting authors to proofread their text. Hating the cover I have designed, redesigning it a couple of times and ended up with several options that I can't decide between. Relying on my classmates for advice. Being at the studio every day. Ordering paper. Spending money on my project (it's expensive to make a master's project). Planning the spring exhibition.



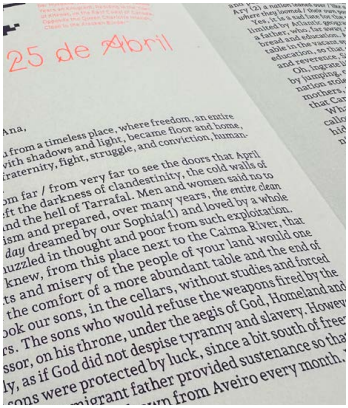
Paper

Arctic Paper's Munken was my main paper option, it's commonly used in design and made in Sweden/Poland, creating a smaller footprint and a faster delivery.

As it's the paper we mostly use at GFI at Konstfack, it's also easy to order. Earlier, I thought of experimenting more with paper, yet I found a lack of in-person stores with a wide range of paper in Stockholm. After all, online shopping paper is far from ideal.

I ended up choosing Munken print cream for the inside stock and (have to check the name at school) for the cover stock.

I also risoprinted on various Munken paper, making it easier to make this choice.

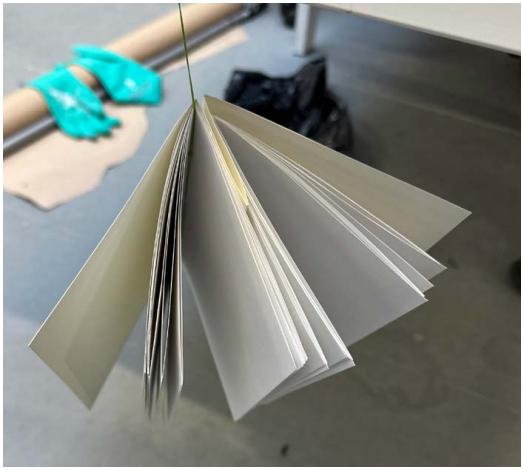



tuca


FL76

Book binding research

I initially planned to use a single-signature saddle stitch for the 100 copies to keep the binding practical and fast. However, once I made the decision for the book to be bilingual, a single signature seemed too bulky. Therefore, I searched for techniques that would remain easy while having two signatures. I encountered many ways, tried out different techniques, and many mockups were made. Yet the one that worked the best was a two-signature binding technique close to saddle stitch, where the stitch goes through an internal cover fold. This creates a separation between signatures, which works well structurally to give me a sturdy book and creates a visual barrier between each language/signature.



I followed book arts professor Jim Escalante's tutorial for this binding technique. resource link: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=W0k1PVf9UIs

Making a book binding cradle

A bookbinding cradle is a tool that helps punch holes in signatures, keeping them lined up. With 90–100 books to bind, these kinds of tools are necessary. We don't have one in the studio. I considered multiple options. Making it out of wood, but since I'm a bit scared of the wood workshop, that option was quickly left. Then I realised I could 3d print it, I looked at many models and searched for leftover filament so I wouldn't have to raise the cost of materials. After a couple of failed tries, it was done! And it will be a tool I'll be carrying with me for future book binding.




20
Wands


20
Wands

Building Week

From the 5th to the 12th of May, it was time to build. It was intense as expected. I wasn't able to bind more books as planned. I changed plans time and time again. Even though I started the week with a tight schedule, it ended up changing every day.

Build the bench, paint it white, spray paint the bench, urgh, I hate it, paint it white again, find another way to add ornament to the benches. And done.

Make a mockup of the large textile, prepare the file, get advised to do it small, following that advice, regretting it, trying to buy more textile, there is not enough textile at the store now, redesigning for a still large but not as big as planned, sublimating the textile, sewing the textile, scheduling to having it put up, searching for an iron, ironing, it goes up, steaming it. And done.

Measure the wall, design the mural, borrow a projector, project the drawing on the wall, realise the distance is not big enough, find a new solution, change spaces and project on a roll of paper, trace the mural in the paper, bring back the paper to the exhibition space,

tape it to the wall, transfer the paper trace to the wall, tape the drawing, spray paint a bit, looks bad, paint it white again, get advice from classmates, redo it with some help, tape and untape sections, wait for drying, ran out of spray paint, go buy more, comeback, spraypaint, finish off details with a paint brush. And done.

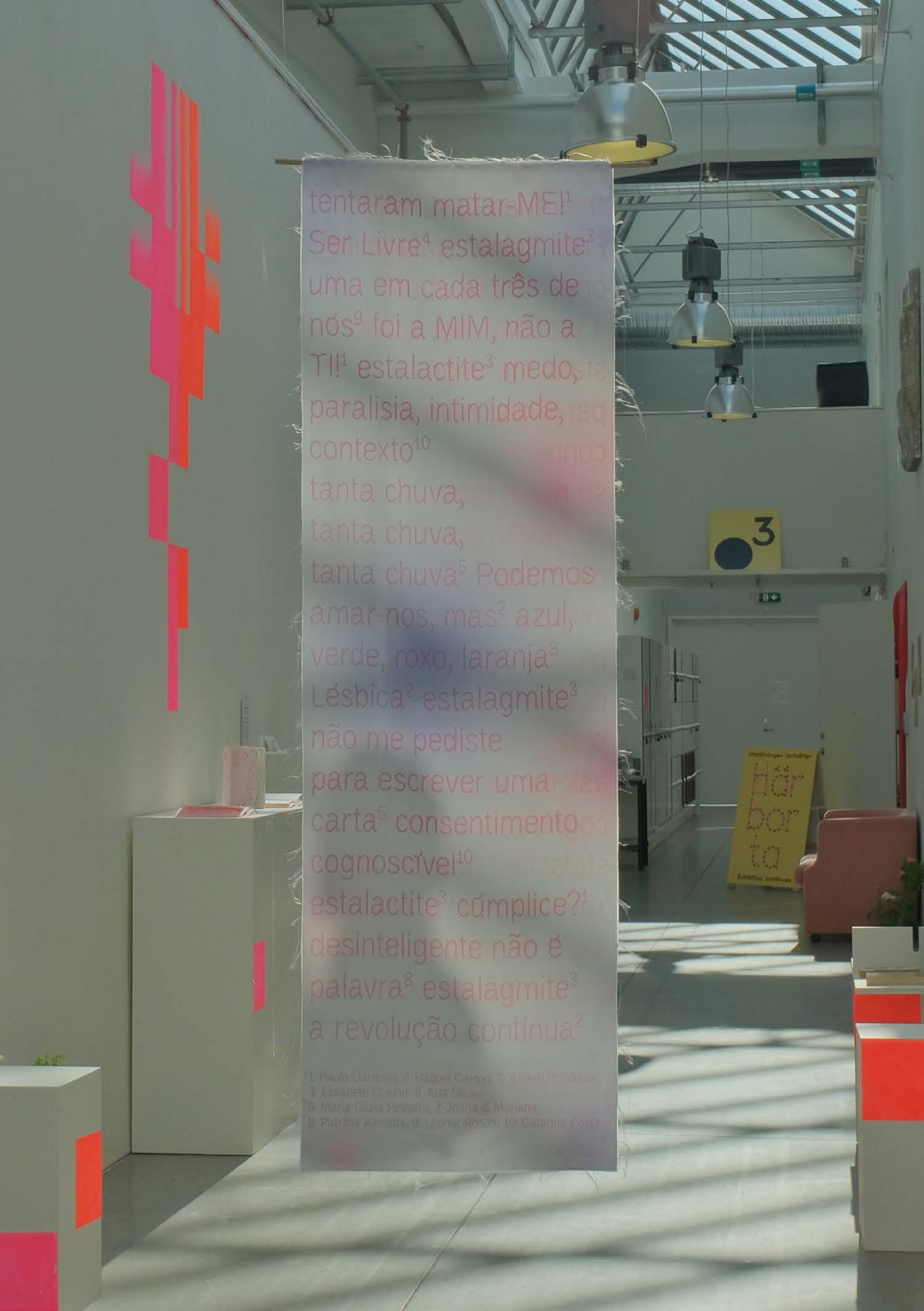
There were, of course, many more processes such as these throughout the week. The first day gave me a lot of confidence in building in the wood workshop, which made the rest of the week much easier, and enabled me to help classmates with wood workshop tasks. This is an example of the set of skills I gained this week that I will take with me, and I'm immensely grateful for.

This was all done with the help of many hands. My classmates and the M1s. And I have to specially thank David for his mural knowledge and help. But most of all, my buddy Sára Somorová, for her tireless work and amazing set of extra eyes.



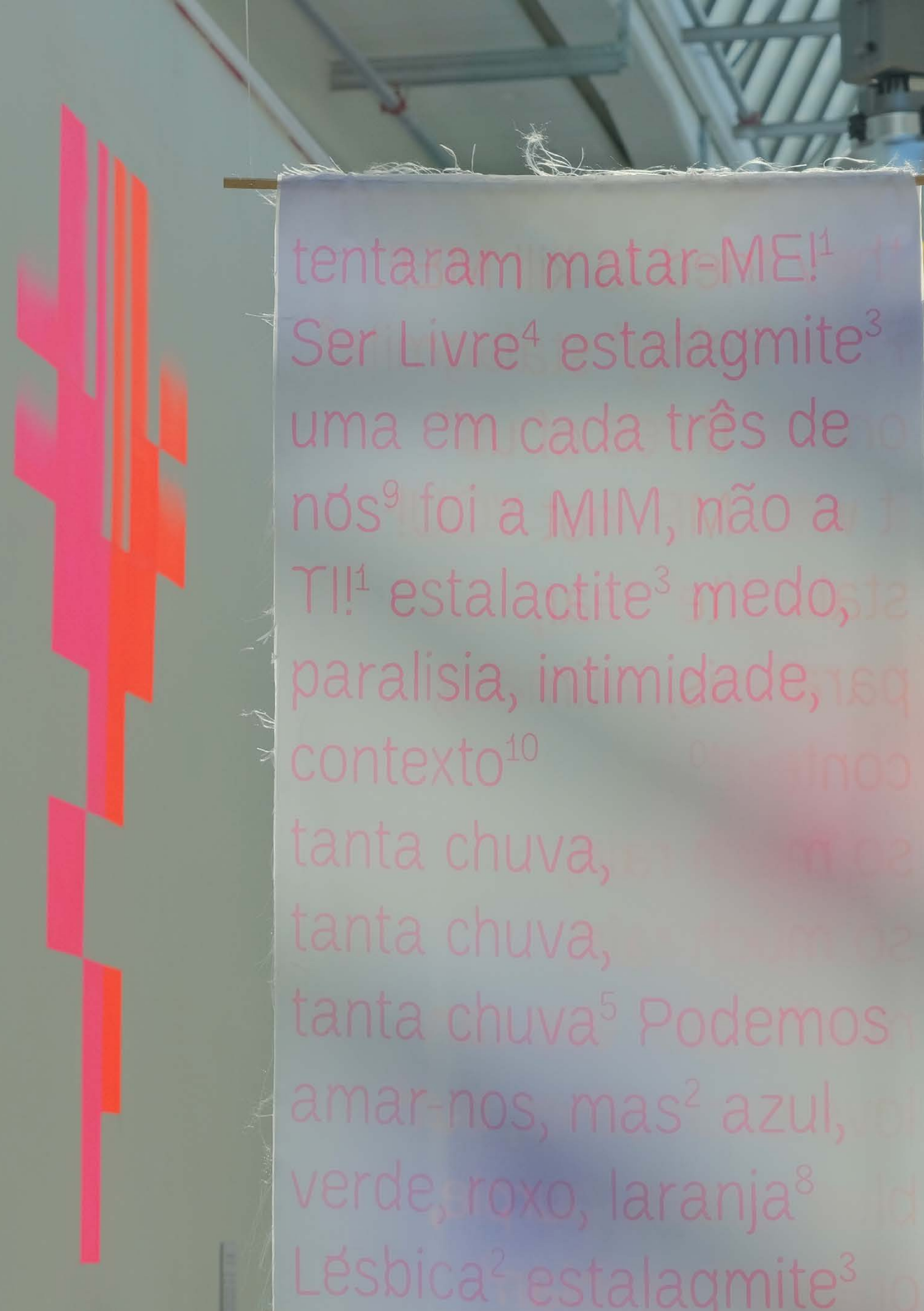




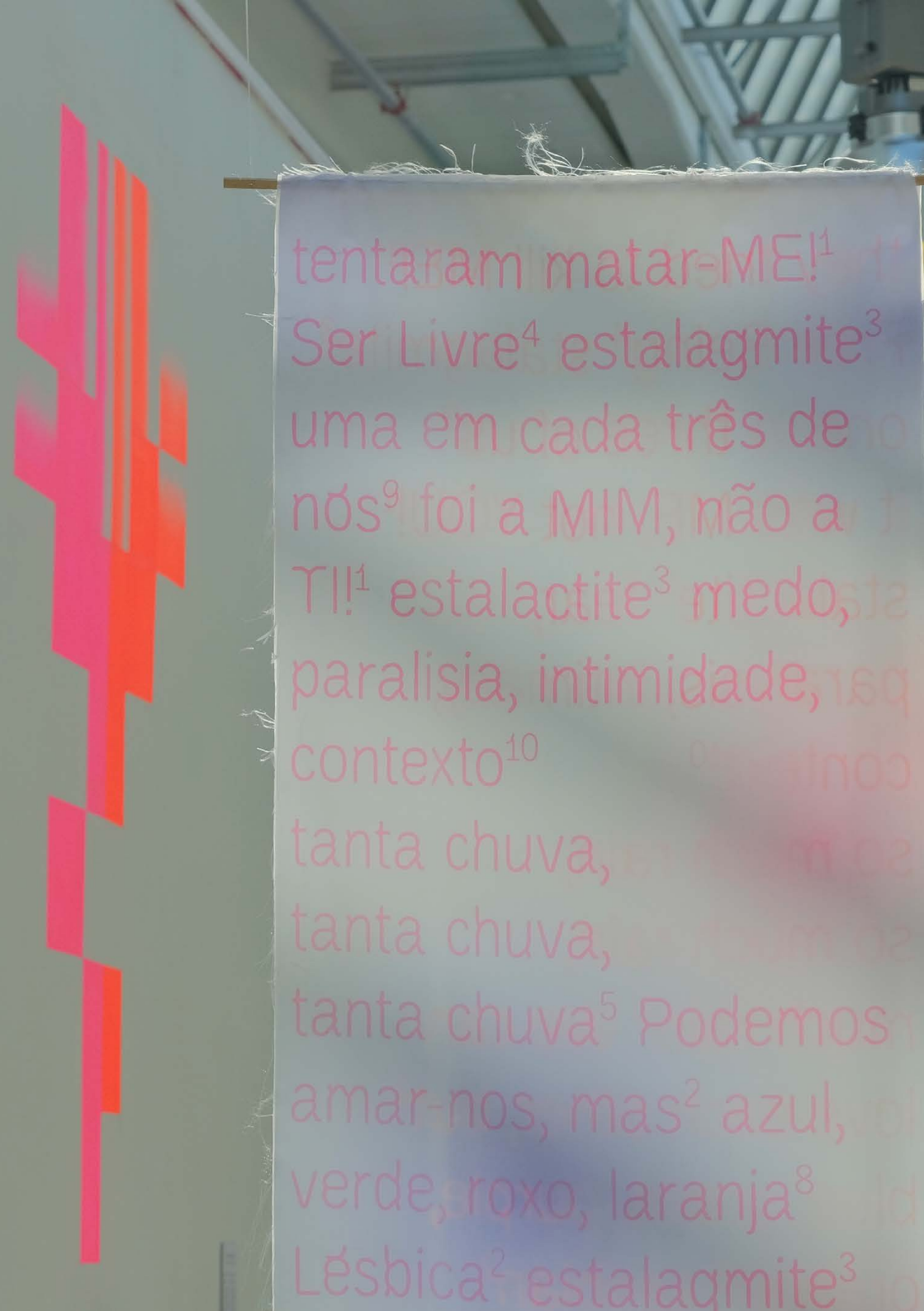

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4. Elisabete Coelho, 5. Ana Silva,
6. Maria Giulia Pinheiro, 7. Joana & Mariana,
8. Patrícia Almeida, 9. Leonor Rosas, 10. Catarina Costa
3
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Archival Library of
"New Portuguese Letters"
by Maria Isabel Barreno, Maria Velho da
Costa, Maria Teresa Horta
NOVAS
CARTAS
PORTUGUESAS
THE THREE MARIAS

novas cartas
Die drei Marias
Neue Portugiesische Briefe


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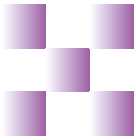
What's next?

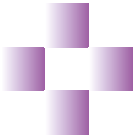
I've learnt a lot these last two years. My hope is to carry this and further grow the project. Maybe have more letters? More editions? Or at least create more independent publishing projects such as this one. However, I hope to have a parallel graphic design practice, which makes this harder. The reality is these projects won't pay the bills. I hope to find a way to manage both in my practice.

In the short term, I have to finish binding all the books and distributing them, hoping they reach as many people as possible.

Ornament as a place of respect

Ornament takes time.
But that time isn't owed to the viewer.
It does not have to exist in abundance
nor overpower other elements.





Ornament can.
Ornament shouldn't dictate.
Ornament should not become authoritarian.
It is political and it's not only decorative.
To state that something is not political is a
political stance.

Ornament is sensitive it
considers its surroundings
and chooses its place.
Ornament is decorative, yet
not always solely.
Typography is not the
opposite of ornament.
Typography can become
ornamental.
Ornament does not
stagnate.
Ornament grows
and changes.